The Great Law of Peace

Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy · founded c. 1450 (pre-contact)

Source: Arthur C. Parker, The Constitution of the Five Nations (New York State Museum Bulletin 184, 1916), text via archive.org. Public domain.

Long before European contact, five nations — the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca (joined by the Tuscarora c. 1722) — united under a single Great Law of Peace to form the Haudenosaunee, or Iroquois, Confederacy. A council of chiefs (sachems) governed by consensus. The Confederacy demonstrates the political sophistication and lasting institutions of Indigenous North America centuries before Europeans arrived. Preserved orally for generations, the law was written down only much later.

Connect: How does the Great Law challenge the idea that complex, organized government "began" in North America with European colonization?

Key Passages

Planting the Tree of Peace

I am Dekanawidah and with the Five Nations' Confederate Lords I plant the Tree of the Great Peace. … There shall you sit and watch the Council Fire of the Confederacy of the Five Nations, and all the affairs of the Five Nations shall be transacted at this place before you, Adodarhoh, and your cousin Lords, by the Confederate Lords of the Five Nations.

Removing a chief

If at any time it shall be manifest that a Confederate Lord has not in mind the welfare of the people or disobeys the rules of this Great Law, the men or the women of the Confederacy, or both jointly, shall come to the Council and upbraid the erring Lord through his War Chief. … The War Chiefs shall then divest the erring Lord of his title by order of the women in whom the titleship is vested. … The women will then select another of their sons as a candidate and the Lords shall elect him.

The duty of the chiefs

The thickness of their skin shall be seven spans — which is to say that they shall be proof against anger, offensive actions and criticism. … With endless patience they shall carry out their duty and their firmness shall be tempered with a tenderness for their people. … In all of your deliberations in the Confederate Council, in your efforts at law making, in all your official acts, self interest shall be cast into oblivion.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Before European contact (c. 1450), the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca ended generations of warfare by uniting under one law, forming the Haudenosaunee (Iroquois) Confederacy.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The member nations and their chiefs (sachems), clan mothers, and people, who passed the law down orally; it was written down for outsiders only in the early 1900s (Parker, 1916).

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	From the perspective of the Haudenosaunee themselves, preserved through oral tradition; the English text is a later transcription and translation, so some wording reflects the recorders.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. SAQ practice (A·C·E): Identify ONE way the Great Law shows political complexity in pre-contact North America.
2. What qualities does the Great Law expect of its leaders, and why might those matter for a confederacy?
3. Why is a source preserved orally for generations both valuable and challenging for historians to use?